

Parts Of a Website: A Cheat Sheet for Non-Techies

By Mark Brinker / Updated: January 23, 2026

Basic Anatomy of a Website

Let's start by defining the various parts of a website:

Header

The header is the top section of a website, where you'll usually find the logo and the site's navigation menu. It's that steady, reliable part of the page that stays visible no matter where visitors click on your site.

Years ago, headers often featured big banners or graphics to promote a brand—similar to the cover photo on a Facebook page. But these days, the trend is to keep things simple, with just a logo, navigation, and possibly a call-to-action button to keep your website looking clean and modern.



Pre-Header

The pre-header is the thin strip that sits above the main header. It's often used to display helpful information like your contact details, business hours, special offers, or even secondary navigation links. Think of it as a small but mighty space for quick-access details that your visitors might appreciate seeing right away.



Favicon

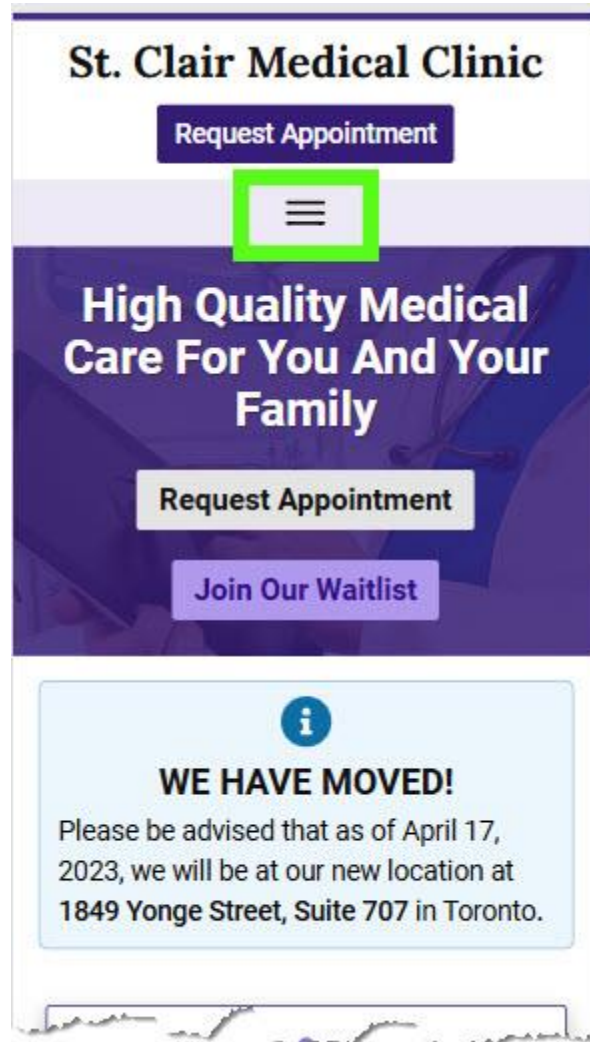
A favicon is the small icon that appears in a browser tab next to your website title. It's usually a simplified version of your logo or brand mark. Favicons help visitors quickly identify your website when they have multiple tabs open, and they add a polished, professional look to your site.

Navigation (aka Navigation Bar or Main Menu)

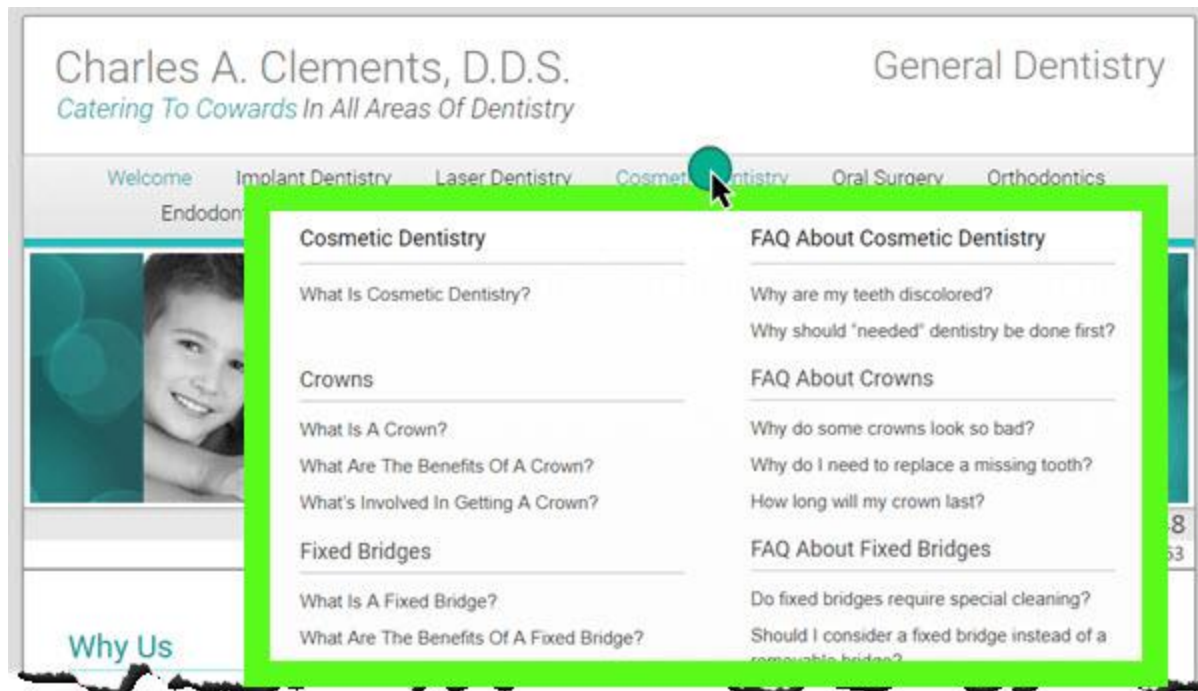
The navigation is the set of links at the top of a website that helps visitors find what they're looking for. These links are usually part of the header or located just below it.



On mobile devices, navigation links often transform into an icon with three stacked lines—commonly called a “hamburger” menu because it resembles a side view of a hamburger. Tapping this icon reveals a vertical toggle or horizontal flyout menu, making it easy to browse even on smaller screens.



For more complex websites with tons of pages, you might encounter a “mega menu.” This is a dropdown menu that appears when you hover over or click a link in the main navigation. It displays multiple categories and subcategories, neatly organizing many links—kind of like a visual sitemap.



Breadcrumbs

Breadcrumbs are a type of navigation that shows visitors their location within a website’s hierarchy. They usually appear near the top of the page and look something like this:

Home > Blog > Latest Posts > Post Title

Breadcrumbs make it easy for visitors to understand where they are on your site and quickly backtrack to previous pages. They’re especially helpful for larger websites with lots of categories and subpages.

Website Content

When it comes to written text, you’ll often hear it called web copy or body copy, but website content goes beyond just words.

Website content is **everything** on your site that communicates your message to visitors. It includes all the elements people interact with—text, images, videos, audio, and more. It’s the full collection of materials designed to inform, engage, or persuade your audience—the whole package, or as some might say, the whole shebang.

Homepage (or home page)

The homepage — also called the front page or main page — is the starting point of most websites. It’s often the first page visitors see and serves as a central hub to guide them through your site.

The homepage sets the tone for the entire website, giving visitors a quick sense of who you are, what you do, and where they should go next. It’s like the front door to your business online.

Common elements on a home page include:

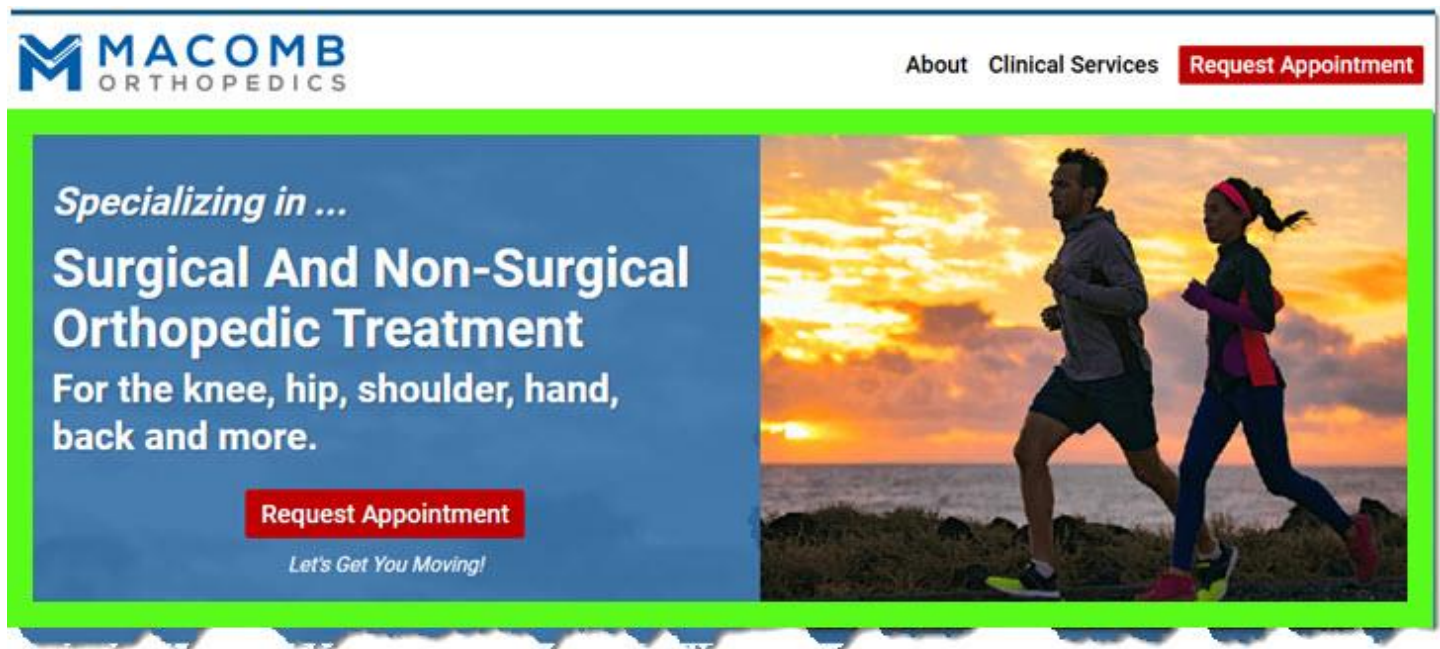
- A hero area (headline and image) to grab attention.
- A navigation menu to help visitors find key pages.
- Links or sections highlighting your most important content, services, or calls to action.

A common website design best practice is to link your logo to the home page. This gives visitors an easy “escape” or “reset” if they ever get lost while navigating your site.

Homepage Hero Area (aka Feature Area aka Headline Area)

The Homepage Hero Area is the top section of a homepage that grabs your attention and introduces the site’s primary message. It often spans the full width of the page and typically includes key elements like:

- A headline that clearly communicates the site’s purpose or the problem it solves.
- A sub-headline that adds supporting details or context.
- A call-to-action button to encourage visitors to take their next step, such as scheduling a consultation or exploring services.
- A visual element, such as an image, graphic, or video, that enhances the message and creates visual interest.



The term “hero” comes from traditional print media, where it referred to the main headline and image meant to grab attention. In web design, the hero area serves a similar purpose: to create an immediate and lasting impression.

Slider

A slider is a feature on a website that displays a rotating series of images, like a slideshow. The images usually slide horizontally from one to the next, though some sliders use fade effects instead.



You'll most often find sliders on homepages, either as a replacement for a hero image or as an additional design element.

While sliders used to be a common design trend, their popularity has decreased in recent years. because they can slow down your site's load time and don't always offer the best experience for mobile users. Although sliders can add some visual interest, sliders are often more decorative than practical.

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Alt Text

Alt text (short for "alternative text") is a brief description added to images on a website. It serves two main purposes:

1. It makes websites more accessible by describing images to visually impaired users who rely on screen readers.
2. It helps search engines understand what an image is about, which can improve your website's SEO.

For example, if you have an image of an office space, instead of leaving it without a description, you might add alt text like: *"Photo of a modern office space with large windows and desks."*

Sidebar

A sidebar is the narrow vertical column that appears alongside your main website content. It's often used to display things like advertisements, links to other content, calls to action, or a search box. Think of it as a supporting area for secondary information that complements the primary content.

In recent years, many websites have moved away from using sidebars altogether, opting instead for a single, full-width layout. For some websites, removing the sidebar makes sense; for others, it doesn't. The decision really comes down to personal preference, the user experience you want to create, and which layout (sidebar vs. no sidebar) works better for your goals—like improving readability or increasing conversions.



Sub-Footer

The sub-footer is the section that appears at the bottom of a webpage—just above the main footer—and is consistent across your site. Think of it as a secondary navigation bar that provides additional points of access or contact details once visitors have scrolled through the primary content. While its content varies by site, a sub-footer typically includes elements such as:

- **Quick Contact Information:** Displaying addresses or phone numbers for immediate reference.
- **Supplementary Navigation Links:** Offering shortcuts to key pages like “About Us,” “Services,” or even “Our Locations.”
- **Social Media Icons:** Allowing visitors easy access to your social profiles. Allowing visitors easy access to your social profiles.
- **Additional Resources:** This might include links to site maps or ancillary informational pages.

The sub-footer is designed to serve as an added layer of user convenience, enriching the overall navigation experience without being as formal as the main footer.

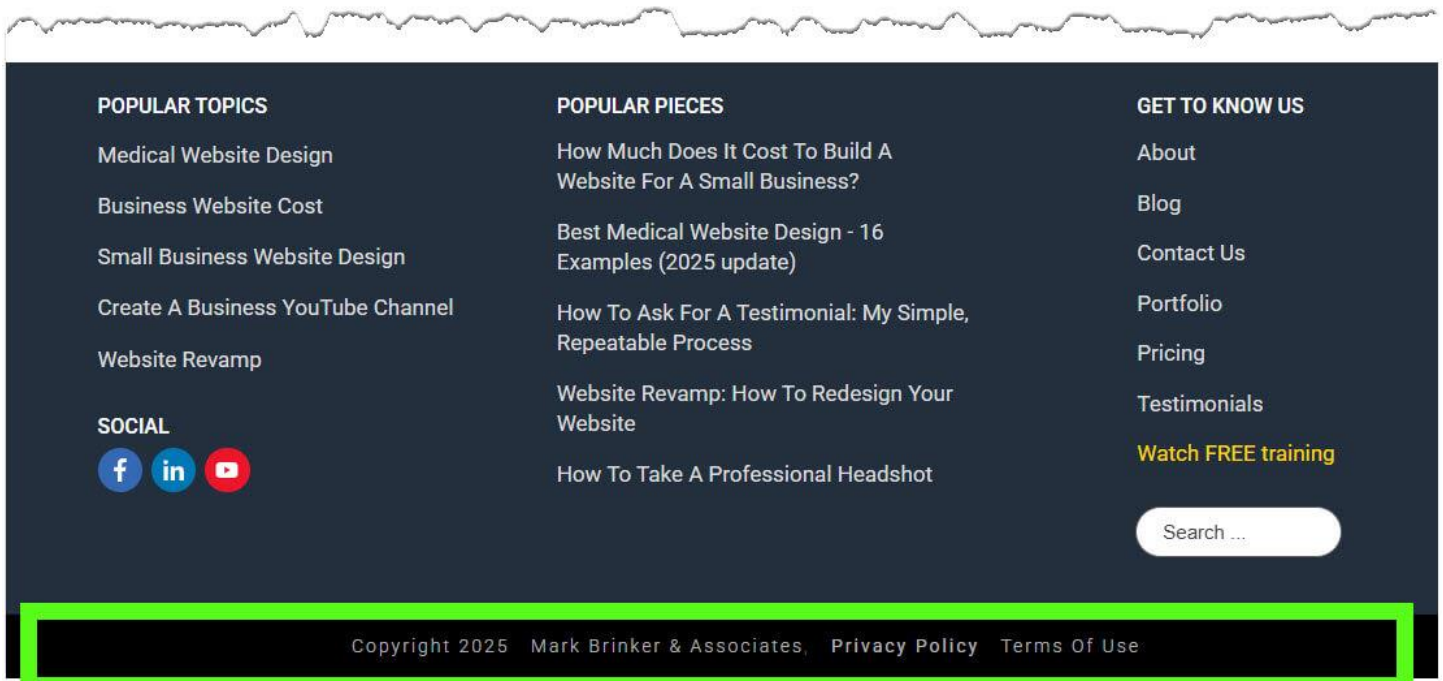


Footer (The "True" Footer)

The footer is the final, definitive section at the very bottom of a webpage. It typically contains essential legal, informational, and administrative details that are less frequently updated but are critical for compliance and user trust. Common footer contents include:

- **Copyright and Legal Disclaimers:** Noting trademark rights and the copyright year.
- **Policy Links:** Links to the privacy policy, terms of use, and any other legal information.
- **Site Map:** A detailed breakdown of the website's structure for improved navigation and SEO.

This section is static across the entire site and represents the definitive end point of your webpage content.



Note: Although many people refer to both areas (i.e. sub-footer and footer) as the “footer,” they're actually two different things. The sub-footer typically contains secondary navigation and quick-access details, whereas the “true” footer is reserved for legal and administrative information.

Landing Page

A landing page is a specific page on your website where visitors “land” after clicking on an ad—whether it’s from Google, Facebook, or anywhere else.

Landing pages are designed differently than regular website pages. Distractions like headers, footers, and sidebars are often removed or minimized to keep visitors focused.

The main goal of a landing page is to get the visitor to take a specific action—like downloading a report, signing up for an email list, or making a purchase. To maximize conversions, the content on a landing page is laser-focused, guiding visitors toward that single objective.

Call To Action (aka CTA)

A call to action (or CTA) is a specific and direct request asking visitors to take a desired action. CTAs can take many forms: buttons, popups, ribbons, slide-ins, email opt-in boxes, or even a simple text link.

A good call to action doesn’t have to be pushy or over-the-top. Sometimes a simple “click here” or “learn more” works perfectly. The key is to gently nudge your visitors toward the next step you want them to take—whether that’s signing up, making a purchase, or contacting you.

Above the Fold

“Above the fold” refers to the part of a webpage you immediately see before you start scrolling. Placing your call-to-action (CTA) above the fold ensures visitors see it right away, increasing the likelihood they’ll take action—like clicking a button or filling out a form.

The term “above the fold” comes from the **newspaper** industry, where the most important headlines and images were placed on the top half of a folded newspaper to grab readers’ attention with a quick glance — like when they walk past a newsstand.

Blog

A blog is a type of website—or a section of a larger website—that features content published as individual posts in chronological order, like journal entries in a diary.

So what’s the difference between a blog and a standard website? It comes down to how the content is structured and presented:

- Blog posts are organized chronologically, often allowing for reader interactivity through comments.
- Web pages (like the homepage, about page, or contact page) are static, not time-based, and don’t typically include comments.

Blogs also tend to have a more casual, conversational tone compared to standard web pages, which are usually more formal and informational, focusing on products, services, or company details.

A blog can stand alone as its own website, or it can live as a section within a larger website—just like this blog post you’re reading right now.

For more info on the similarities and differences between a blog and a website, check out my video on my YouTube channel.

Card Design (aka Tile Design or Grid-Based Design)

Card design organizes content into visually distinct “cards” or tiles, often arranged in a grid layout. Popularized by sites like Pinterest, this design style is clean, easy to scan, and works well on both desktop and mobile devices.

Card design can be used in a variety of ways:

- **Image galleries**
- **Blog pages** to showcase multiple posts
- **Sales pages** to highlight features, benefits, or services

It’s a flexible, visually appealing way to present information. With a little creativity, the possibilities are endless.

IVANHOE

HOME WHAT WE DO **PORTFOLIO** ABOUT US



SORT BY TITLE SHOW ALL SINGLE FAMILY RESIDENTIAL COMMERCIAL MULTI-FAMILY



Addington Corners
Commerce Township



Barrington Park
Rochester Hills



Beacon Hill
Novi



Berkshire Creek
Ann Arbor



Berkshire Point
Novi



Birchwood Park
West Bloomfield



Bristol Corners
Novi



Brookfield Village
West Bloomfield



Carnegie Park
Southfield



Carrington Gardens
West Bloomfield

Hosting

To have a website on the internet, it needs to be **hosted** on a web server. Think of hosting as the piece of land where your website “lives.” Just like you need land to build a house, you need a server to store your website’s files and make them available to people on the internet.

There are plenty of companies that offer website hosting services, like HostGator or BlueHost, which rent out space on their servers so your site can be available online 24/7.

Caching

Caching is the process of storing a temporary version of a website or webpage to help it **load faster**. When someone visits your website, a cached version can be delivered quickly instead of forcing the browser to fetch everything from scratch.

Caching improves site speed, reduces the load on your web server, and makes for a smoother experience for visitors—especially for those who come back to your site repeatedly.

Domain Name (aka URL)

A domain name is the address people type into their browser to visit a website—like Amazon.com, CNN.com, or markbrinker.com.

Behind the scenes, every website is identified by an IP address, which is a long string of numbers like 143.398.884.342. But let’s be honest—who can remember all those digits? That’s why domain names exist: they’re easier to remember and use words instead of numbers to identify a website.

Fun fact: The term URL stands for Uniform Resource Locator — it’s the technical name for a web address.

Domain Registrar

A domain registrar is where you purchase and register your domain name—kind of like getting a license plate for your car from the DMV.

There are plenty of domain registrars online, such as [NameCheap.com](https://www.namecheap.com) or GoDaddy. Once you register your domain name, it’s officially yours (as long as you keep renewing it).

301 Redirect

A 301 redirect is a way to permanently send visitors (and search engines) from one URL to another. It’s often used when you update your website’s structure, change a page’s URL, or move your site to a new domain.

For example, if you change a page’s URL from yourwebsite.com/**services** to yourwebsite.com/**our-services**, a 301 redirect ensures anyone visiting the old link will automatically land on the new page. It also tells search engines to pass along any SEO value from the old URL to the new one.

404 Error Page

A 404 error page appears when someone tries to visit a page on your website that doesn’t exist — either because the page was deleted, the URL was mistyped, or the link is broken.

While a default 404 page simply tells visitors the page can’t be found, a well-designed 404 page can do more. It can include helpful links, a search bar, or even a friendly message to guide visitors back to where they want to go, instead of leaving them frustrated.

DNS

DNS stands for **Domain Name System**. Think of it as the phone book of the internet.

As mentioned earlier, humans use domain names (like markbrinker.com) instead of long, hard-to-remember IP addresses. When you type a domain name into your web browser, your internet service provider (ISP) connects to a **domain name server**—one of many located around the world. The DNS server quickly looks up the IP address linked to that domain name and routes you to the website you requested.

Mobile Responsive

A mobile responsive website automatically morphs to fit the shape and size of the screen it's being viewed on—whether that's a phone, tablet, or desktop. It uses CSS to adjust the layout, navigation, and font sizes seamlessly, so the site is easy to use and read on any device.

More than 50% of all web traffic comes from mobile devices, so mobile responsive design has become the standard for modern websites. If you have to pinch and zoom to make text readable, that's a sure sign the website is **not** mobile friendly.

SSL

SSL stands for Secure Socket Layer. An SSL certificate encrypts the data sent between a website's server and your browser, ensuring that hackers can't intercept or read it.

You can tell if a website is secure by looking for the padlock icon in your browser's address bar:

- A **non-secure** website starts with “**http**” (Hyper Text Transfer Protocol).
- A **secure** website starts with “**https**”, where the “s” stands for **secure**.

SSL certificates have become standard for **all websites**, even those that don't collect sensitive information like contact details or payment data. Visitors expect to see the SSL padlock icon, and web browsers often flag non-SSL websites with warnings that can make users feel nervous or unsafe.

SEO

SEO stands for Search Engine Optimization. It's the process of configuring your website to get free traffic from search engine results pages (often referred to as SERPs).

SEO can seem like a large and complex topic—and it is—but at its core, it's about creating content that search engines value and people actually want. To get ranked in the organic search listings, you need to produce content that:

- Is high quality and genuinely helpful.
- People actually want to read, share, or link to.
- Is properly formatted on your site (known as On-Page SEO).

That said, there's a lot of confusion and wildly unrealistic expectations around SEO. It's important to know that SEO takes time, effort, and strategy to be effective.